The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Donald Trump said America would “immediately” provide insurance for shipping lines travelling through the **Strait of Hormuz**, and that the navy would escort oil tankers if necessary. The details of the plan remain unclear. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, the regime’s praetorian guard, declared Hormuz closed on Monday, warning to set ablaze any ship that passes. The route transports a third of global seaborne crude and a fifth of liquefied natural gas transit daily.

Israel said it had killed a commander of the Quds Force, the foreign arm of the IRGC. The commander reportedly co-ordinated with **Hizbullah**, an Iran-backed militia. Israel also said it struck a compound in Iran that it claimed was being used to develop nuclear weapons. Meanwhile Israel’s offensive against Hizbullah in Lebanon intensified as the pair traded missiles.

The sell-off of **stocks** and **bonds** accelerated, with Britain’s FTSE 100 index falling by 3% on Tuesday, and America’s S&P 500 closing down by almost 1%. Rising oil and gas prices have stoked fears of inflation, pushing up global bond yields and reducing traders’ expectations of interest-rate cuts.

The European Central Bank warned of a renewed spike in **inflation** in **Europe** as new data showed an unexpected rise in prices even before the latest conflict in the Middle East. Annual inflation in the euro zone climbed to 1.9% in February, surpassing forecasts and up from 1.7% in January. Although the headline rate remains below the ECB's 2% target, core inflation increased to 2.4% in February, driven by a surge in the price of services.

The chair of the Federal Communications Commission, Brendan Carr, said he expects swift approval for Paramount's $111bn bid to buy **Warner Bros Discovery**, a rival film studio. He called it "cleaner" than Netflix's competing offer, which he said "raised a lot of competition concerns". Both bids triggered antitrust concerns around job losses and fewer films being made.

America imposed sanctions on the **Rwandan army** and four of its top officers for training and supporting a rebel group in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo. America accuses M23 of "extrajudicial killings, arbitrary arrests and torture", even after Mr Trump brokered a peace deal between Rwanda and the DRC in December.

OpenAI's boss, Sam Altman, said the artificial-intelligence company would change a deal it struck with America's Department of War to limit the use of its tools to surveil Americans. The two parties reached the agreement shortly after the Trump administration banned federal agencies from using the technology of Anthropic, a rival AI lab, because it refused to allow its products to be used for mass domestic surveillance.

Figure of the day: 14%, how much more likely it is that a cancer patient will commit a crime in the decade after their diagnosis than someone without cancer, according to a recent study. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

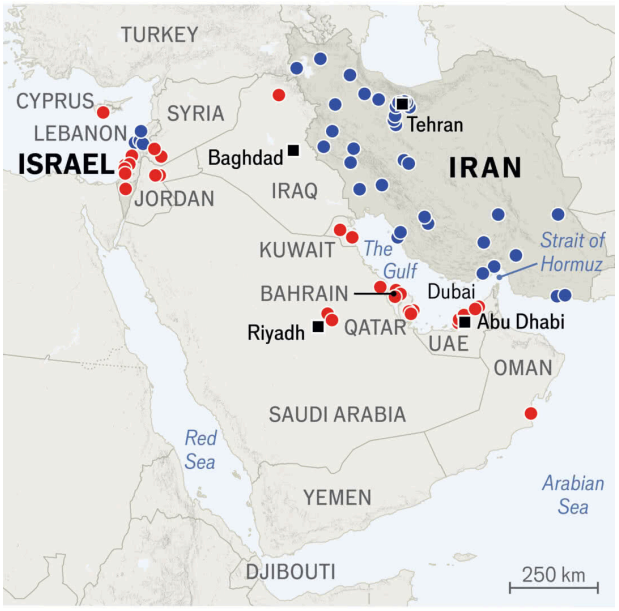
“Horizontal escalation” in the Middle East

The war in Iran is widening. Iran’s retaliation against Gulf Arab states has been faster and more aggressive than many expected, targeting airports and energy infrastructure. Hizbullah, the Lebanese militant group, has fired rockets and drones at northern Israel. And Israel is bombing Beirut, Lebanon’s capital. A suspected Iranian drone struck a British military base in Cyprus. Britain has said America can use its airfields for its war.

How long can this last? Donald Trump has suggested as many as “four to five weeks”. It is not clear who in Iran would be in a position to lead hypothetical negotiations with America, given that 49 of its leaders have been killed. Iran was thought to have enough missiles to sustain its current rate of fire for weeks. Launchers that emerge from hiding, however, will be hunted not just by Israel, as in last year’s conflict, but also by America. “Prepare for many prolonged days of combat,” assesses Eyal Zamir, chief of staff of the Israel Defence Forces.

Reported air strikes, at March 2nd 18:30 GMT

● United States and Israel ● Iran



Sources: Liveuamap.com; press reports

Photograph: Reuters

War in Iran spells major trouble for Turkey

Deepening conflict in the Middle East raises the prospect of renewed inflation. That could spell big trouble for Turkey's economy in particular. The spike in energy prices and potential disruptions to supplies from Iran—which accounts for roughly 14% of Turkey's gas imports—threaten to deliver a body blow. Thanks to high interest rates, inflation has been falling from a peak of over 80% in 2022. Data released Tuesday showed annual inflation at 31.5%, a slight increase on the previous month's figures. Chaos in Iran may push prices up further. Turkish markets are already feeling the shock.

Other risks loom. A prolonged war could push hundreds of thousands of refugees towards Turkey, which shares a 534km border with Iran. A civil war in Iran would make matters even worse. A Kurdish uprising in Iran could also upend Turkey's peace talks with its own Kurdish insurgents. The country has every right to be extremely nervous.

Photograph: Reuters

Democrats hope to flip a Senate seat in Texas

On Tuesday Texans will choose Senate nominees in primaries that could shape who controls Congress come November's midterms. Democrats sniff a chance of flipping a seat in America's biggest red state for the first time since 1988.

Republicans must pick between John Cornyn, a four-term incumbent who calls himself a "work-horse" and sometimes dares to work with Democrats, and Ken Paxton, the combative attorney-general who boasts of suing Joe Biden 107 times. Mr Paxton also has his own legal troubles, which he casts as a Trump-style witch-hunt. Polls are tight; a run-off favouring Mr Paxton looks likely.

Democrats face their own electability test. Jasmine Crockett, a sharp-tongued congresswoman (pictured right), delights activists by hurling viral insults at Republicans online. James Talarico, a 36-year-old former teacher and seminarian (pictured left), offers a calmer populism that appeals even to conservatives. If he wins and faces Mr Paxton, national Democrats will flood Texas with cash. To control the Senate, the party has to win red-leaning states.

Photograph: Reuters

Britain’s chancellor plays it safe

On Tuesday the Office for Budget Responsibility published its outlook for the British economy and public finances. Rachel Reeves kept her response to the independent forecaster’s findings simple in a statement to Parliament. After last November’s chaotic budget, the chancellor wanted the event to be as boring as possible. She made no real policy announcements, and stressed the “stability” of the public finances as the government faces the potential economic consequences of the war in Iran.

The OBR’s numbers looked broadly similar to those in the budget, though expected debt costs fell slightly. The real story, though, may be what the OBR didn’t yet account for: sharply lower migration projections, which will constrain economic growth, and mounting pressure on the government to raise defence spending. Those questions could make the budget next autumn less boring than Ms Reeves would like.

Photograph: Getty Images

A nuanced take on Japan’s notorious wartime leader

Biographies of second world war leaders, such as Winston Churchill and Adolf Hitler, are reliable sellers for publishers. But Tojo Hideki, Japan’s prime minister between 1941 and 1944, has for decades been left off English readers’ shelves. Peter Mauch, an Australian historian, has now written “Tojo: The Rise and Fall of Japan’s Most Controversial World War II General”, which is published in America on Tuesday.

Tojo stood trial in front of the Tokyo war-crimes tribunal after Japan’s defeat, and was hanged in 1948. To most Japanese, his bald, bespectacled and moustached face lingers as a symbol of evil. Meanwhile, a nationalist, right-wing fringe has sought to lionise him.

Drawing on newly available sources, including Tojo’s writings and the diaries of his secretaries, Mr Mauch portrays him as “neither hero nor villain”. He delves into the complexities of his life, and shows how absolute loyalty to the emperor and a peerless ability to “navigate and manipulate the complex administrative structures of army and state” drove Japan to ruin.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which book by Nate Silver, published in 2012, is about the art of interpreting statistics?

Monday: Which British newspaper, when owned by Lord Beaverbrook, had the largest circulation in the world in the 1940s?

You cannot force ideas. Successful ideas are the result of slow growth.

Alexander Graham Bell